

# Introduction

While PC enthusiasts will forever remain true to their geek roots, there's no doubt computing is steadily moving towards the portable space. Take a look around you; tablets, smartphones and laptops are ubiquitous, and reports of desktop sales dropping are more common than the next iteration of a brand new Galaxy phone.

This got us thinking... How much does the average user really know about the innards of his or her mobile device? In the case of mobile phones, specifications read like career-criminal rap sheets. You constantly come across terms such as Snapdragon, Tegra, Exynos and the likes. What do these arcane terms mean? Most people believe these are just names of processors – a common misconception. In reality these are SoCs or System On Chips. In the case of laptop hardware, it's easy to assume the speed of the CPU is a measure of its performance. Surely a 3.4 GHz model is faster than a 3.1 GHz model. Not necessarily. While the clock speed-to-performance ratio is stable within the same family of processors, the amount of work done per clock cycle is different for each processor architecture and family. Many more clock cycles may be required by one CPU compared to another to do the same amount of work if they belong to different families. This FastTrack aims to debunk many such misconceptions, effectively making you a portable hardware wiz. With this firm grounding, buying advice will become second nature to you. For instance, say you're on the market for a new laptop. Do you know how to identify new generation Sandy Bridge processors from their older variants just by looking at the model number? With this FastTrack you will.

In addition to all this we provide a comprehensive and handy buying guide to wrap things up. The buying guide is complete with our Top 10 recommendations in each of the categories viz. Mobile, Tablet and Laptop.

As always happy reading, and we look forward to your feedback on [editor@thinkdigit.com](mailto:editor@thinkdigit.com) 